

The Cost of Voting Index

Fifty-six election laws compressed into one number, and the decisions that decide what it says

84-355 Democracy's Data

August 2026

A voter in Oregon is mailed a ballot. It arrives without being asked for, it comes with pre-paid postage, and it can be dropped at a box or put in the mail. Nobody checks identification, because nobody meets the voter.

A voter in Mississippi is not mailed a ballot. To vote absentee they must qualify under one of a fixed list of excuses, request the ballot, enclose a copy of their identification, and **get the envelope notarized**. That last step has no counterpart anywhere in Oregon. To vote in person they must produce a photo ID, on a day that is not a state holiday, at a polling place open for a fixed number of hours, having registered thirty days earlier.

Those are two different acts wearing the same name. The question this chapter is about is what happens when somebody tries to put a number on the difference.

01 Somebody does

The Cost of Voting Index is that number. **Li, Pomante and Schraufnagel (2018)** built it. A team of political scientists reads the election law of all fifty states, scores it against a fixed list of considerations, and compresses the result into a single value per state per election. It has been maintained since 1996 and is republished in a peer-reviewed journal each cycle, most recently by **Pomante (2025)**. And it is used the way such numbers get used: in litigation, in journalism, and in other people's regressions — other people's attempts to draw a best line through a scatter of points.

Item	Value
Who compiles it	Pomante, Schraufnagel and Li (academic researchers)
Published as	A journal article each cycle, plus a project website
Unit	State, in an election year
Coverage	9 elections, 1996-2024, all 50 states
Machine-readable version	Yes – three spreadsheets on the project site
Replication material	The laws, the codebook, and the component weights

That fifth row is worth pausing on, because it is the opposite of the usual situation. Numbers this widely quoted are typically available only as a table inside a report, to be recovered by parsing a PDF by character position, if at all. Here the underlying data, the codebook and the weights are all published, in that order of usefulness. That means **this index can be taken apart and rebuilt**. This chapter does exactly that, because rebuilding it is the only way to see what it is made of.

The rest of this chapter is about four decisions inside that number. None of them is hidden, none is a mistake, and every one of them changes the answer.

02 What a row is

450 rows: fifty states, 9 elections. Each row carries the state's score, its rank, and the ten *issue areas* the score is built from.

State	Reg. deadline	Voter ID	Early voting	Absentee	Inconveniences	COVI	Rank
Oregon	21	0	0	0	2	-2.314250	2
Pennsylvania	15	0	42	3	9	0.399019	26
Mississippi	30	4	42	8	10	2.010490	50

Five of the ten issue areas, for three states. Each column is a different kind of thing, and that is the first thing to notice about the file. **reg. deadline is a number of days** — how far before the election registration closes, so Oregon's 21 means twenty-one days and a same-day state scores zero. **voter ID is a five-point scale**, running from no identification required to strict photo. **absentee and inconveniences are counts of restrictions**, each one a yes-or-no law that either exists in that state or does not. **early voting is a number of days, reversed**, so that more days means a lower number, because everything in the file is oriented so that bigger is worse.

Underneath those ten columns sit 52 individual yes-or-no items — the actual laws. `noallmailvoting`, `nofoodordrink`, `MentalCompReg`, `AddRequirements4mailballotreturn`. The additive issue areas are just those items added up.

Law item	States scoring it	
PR90	1	in only a few states
PR60	1	in only a few states
restrictdistofabsenteeballotscounty	1	in only a few states
NoDriveAllowed	3	in only a few states
NoPostcardAutoreg	40	in nearly every state
noallmailvoting	42	in nearly every state
noallmailornopollocations	43	in nearly every state
NoFelonsReg	48	in nearly every state

52 items, and the range at the two ends of that table is the whole problem of building an index out of them. Some of these laws exist in one state. One of them exists in 48.

03 Fifty-six laws, one number

The recipe is published, and it fits in a sentence. Standardize the ten issue areas, run a principal component analysis, keep the first four components, weight each one by the share of the variation it accounts for, and add them up.

Component	Share of variance explained	Weight in the index
First	0.4709	0.5834
Second	0.1301	0.1612
Third	0.1214	0.1504
Fourth	0.0847	0.1050
Total	0.8072	1.0000

A principal component analysis takes ten correlated columns and finds the directions along which states differ most. The first component is the single line through the data that separates the states as much as possible; the second is the best remaining direction at right angles to it, and so on. Four of them capture 80.7% of the variation across the ten issue areas, and each is weighted by how much of that it accounts for.

Those weights are the project's own published numbers, printed in its codebook. The numbers in the table above were recomputed from the laws, and they agree to four decimal places. That is the first check this chapter can offer.

The stronger check is the whole index:

Check	Result
States rebuilt from the published laws	50
Largest difference from the published score	0.000265
States landing in the same rank	50 of 50
Correlation with the published index	1.000000

The index reproduces exactly. Not approximately. Every state lands in the same rank, and the largest disagreement anywhere is 0.000265 on a scale running from about -2.5 to 2.

That matters for everything below. In a moment this chapter re-weights the index, counting some parts of it for more than others. When it does, it is re-weighting the real thing rather than a model of it.

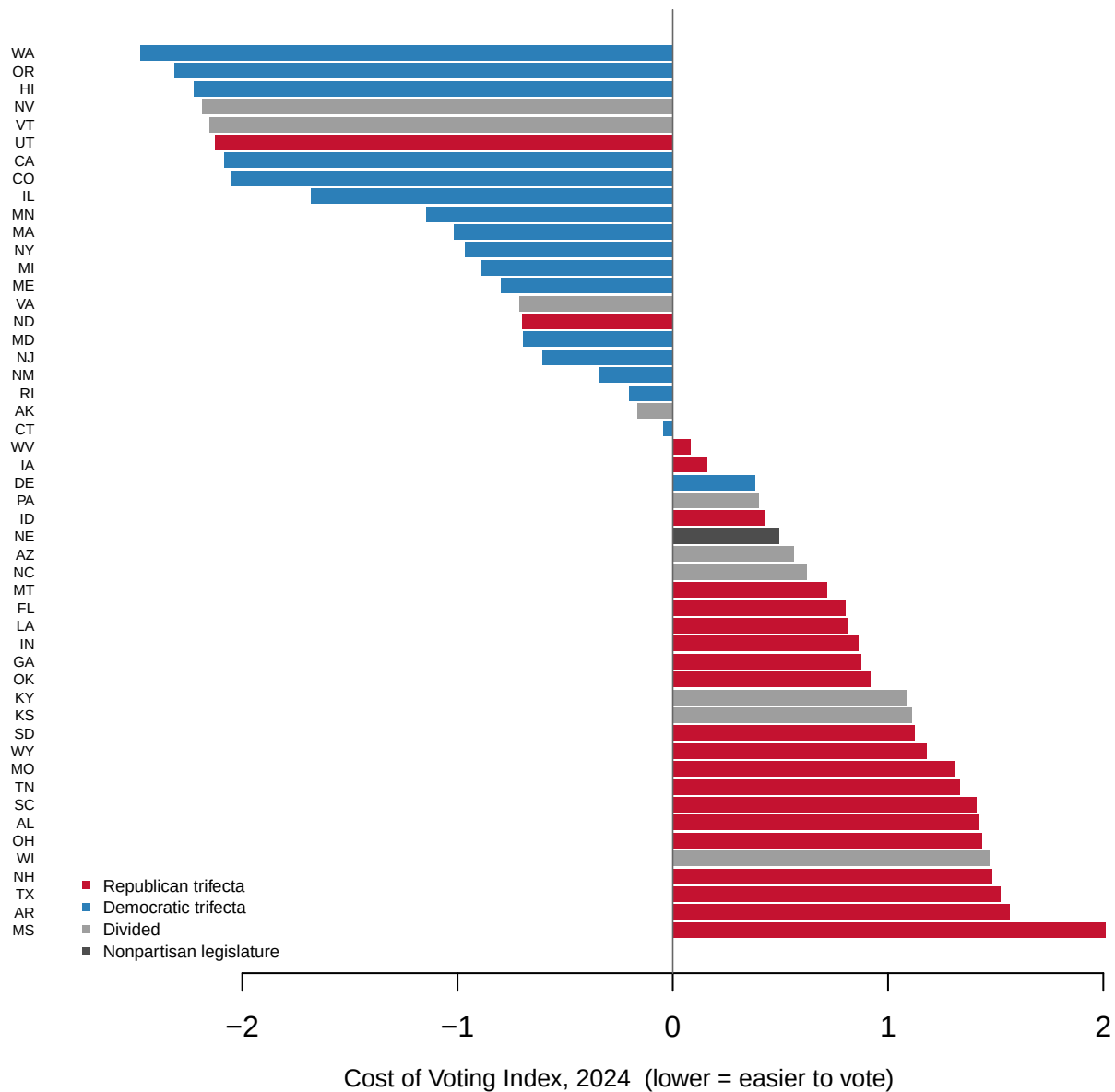


Figure 1. The 2024 Cost of Voting Index, all fifty states. Lower is easier. Washington is lowest at -2.48, Mississippi highest at 2.01. The colour is party control of state government, which the index itself does not contain – it was added here, and the section on polarization below takes up what it shows.

04 The weights nobody chose

Now the first of the four decisions, and it is the one that does the most work.

The index weights each component by **how much variation it explains**. That is a defensible rule and the codebook describes it as letting the data speak for itself. But it has a consequence that is easy to state and hard to unsee: *a law that nearly every state has cannot matter much, no matter how burdensome it is*.

Variance is a measure of disagreement. An item on which forty-eight states agree carries almost none, so it contributes almost nothing to any component, so it is nearly invisible in the score.

Law item	States scoring it	Standard deviation
NoFelonsReg	48	0.20
noallmailornopollocations	43	0.35
noallmailvoting	42	0.37
NoPostcardAutoreg	40	0.40
NoDriveAllowed	3	0.24
PR17	3	0.24
ReducePollingLoc>50%someareas	3	0.24
nofoodordrink	3	0.24
strictID	3	0.24
PR90	1	0.14
PR60	1	0.14
restrictdistofabsenteeballotscounty	1	0.14

The top row is the sharp case. **48 of 50 states forbid people in prison from registering to vote**. As a barrier to voting that is absolute. It is the difference between voting and not voting, for everyone it touches, and roughly four million American adult citizens are on the far side of it (**Uggen and colleagues 2024**). As a *variable* it is nearly worthless, because it barely separates one state from another. It sits in the index carrying a standard deviation of 0.20.

This is not a flaw that anyone concealed; it is what variance weighting means, and it applies to every index built this way. **A variance-weighted index measures how unusual a state is, not how hard it is to vote there**. Those two quantities agree often enough to be useful and they are not the same, and the gap between them is widest exactly where American practice is uniform.

The same logic runs at the level of the ten issue areas:

Issue area	Sd across states	Loading, 1st component	Loading, 2nd
Absentee voting	2.43	0.377	-0.028
Poll hours	2.66	0.376	0.310
Registration restrictions	2.15	0.355	-0.344
Voting inconveniences	2.33	0.344	0.221

Issue area	Sd across states	Loading, 1st component	Loading, 2nd
Early voting days	15.69	0.326	0.385
Automatic registration	1.19	0.314	-0.032
Voter ID	1.45	0.310	-0.116
Registration deadline	13.13	0.303	-0.515
Preregistration	2.51	0.282	0.097
Registration drives	1.50	-0.019	0.547

Nine of the ten issue areas load on the first component at between 0.28 and 0.38, which is what it looks like when restrictive states are restrictive across the board. The exception is **Registration drives**, at -0.019 — an entire issue area that is, to the first component, noise. It has its own dimension: it loads 0.55 on the second. Restrictions on voter registration drives are not a thing restrictive states happen to also do, and the index's headline number therefore has almost nothing to say about them.

05 The same laws, four different answers

Nothing in this section changes a single law. Every state has exactly the laws it has in 2024; only the rule for combining them moves.

Before you read on, commit to a number. The index weights four components by variance. Suppose you weighted them equally instead — a rule at least as easy to defend. **How many places would the worst-affected state move?** Write down a number out of 50. Then write down what you think happens if the ten issue areas are not standardized before the analysis.

Weighting rule	What changes	Mean rank move	Biggest move
Published index	–	–	–
Four components weighted equally	variance weights dropped	5.2	16 (Delaware)
First component alone	the other three components dropped	2.9	15 (Wisconsin)
Issue areas not standardized	days and points left on their own scales	7.9	28 (Rhode Island)

Equal weights move the average state 5.2 places and the worst-affected state 16. Leaving the issue areas unstandardized moves one state 28 places, and the reason is worth naming. Two of the ten issue areas are measured in **days**: the registration deadline and early voting. Their spreads are around 16, against about 1.2 for automatic registration. Skip the standardizing step and those two columns write the index nearly on their own, not because days matter more but because days are numbered higher.

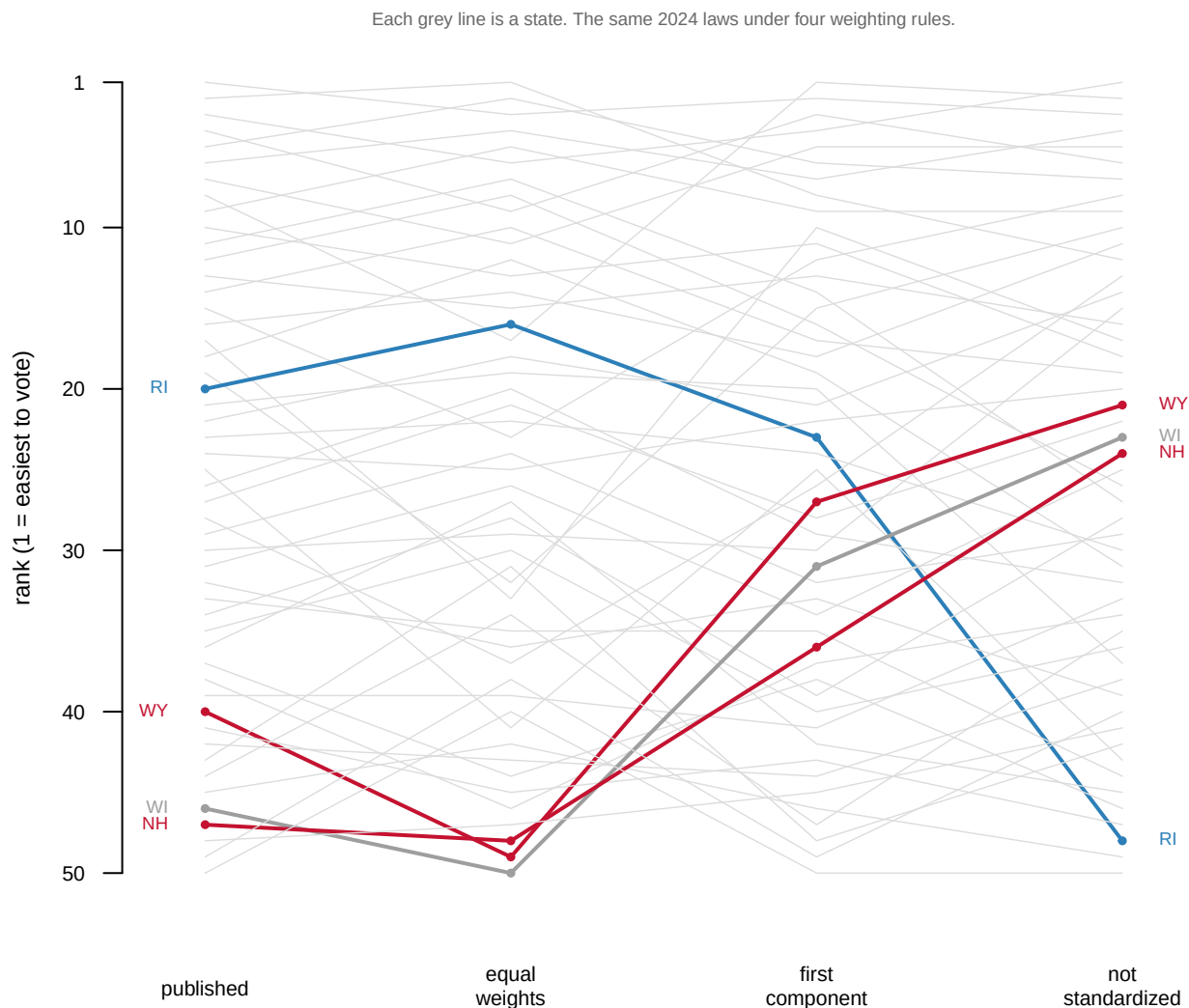


Figure 2. The same fifty states, ranked four ways. Each line is a state, carried from its published rank across three alternative weighting rules. No law changed between the columns. The states highlighted in the print version are the largest movers; in the HTML version, hovering any line follows one state across all four.

The point is not that the published rule is wrong. It is that **the rule is a choice, the choice is not visible in the number, and a state's rank is an artifact of it.** Rhode Island ranks 20 of 50 under the published rule and 48 if the ten issue areas are left unstandardized. A reader given either number has been told something about Rhode Island's laws and something about a decision made in a spreadsheet, in unmarked proportions.

06 Does it predict turnout?

An index of the cost of voting is worth building because of an assumption nobody states: that cost affects behaviour. Higher cost, fewer voters.

Commit to a second number before reading on. Across the fifty states in 2024, **how much of the variation in turnout is explained by the cost of voting?** Write down a percentage from 0 to 100.

Quantity	Value
Correlation, cost against turnout	-0.266
Variation in turnout explained	7.1%
p-value	0.0617
Turnout in the 3 cheapest states	64.1%
Turnout in the 3 most expensive	56.2%

The correlation is -0.266 — negative, so in the expected direction: costlier states do turn out somewhat lower. And it accounts for 7.1% of the variation between states, which at 50 states does not clear the conventional threshold for statistical significance ($p = 0.0617$).

Most readers write down something between 40 and 70.

The individual states say it more plainly than the correlation does.

State	Cost rank	COVI	Turnout
Oregon	2	-2.31	71.9%
Hawaii	3	-2.22	50.3%
Wisconsin	46	1.47	76.7%
Texas	48	1.52	56.8%
Mississippi	50	2.01	57.8%

Hawaii is the 3rd easiest state in the country in which to vote and turns out 50.3% of its eligible adults. Mississippi is the hardest, 50th of 50, and turns out 57.8% — nearly 7 points *higher*. Wisconsin ranks 46th on cost and turns out 76.7%, among the highest in the country.

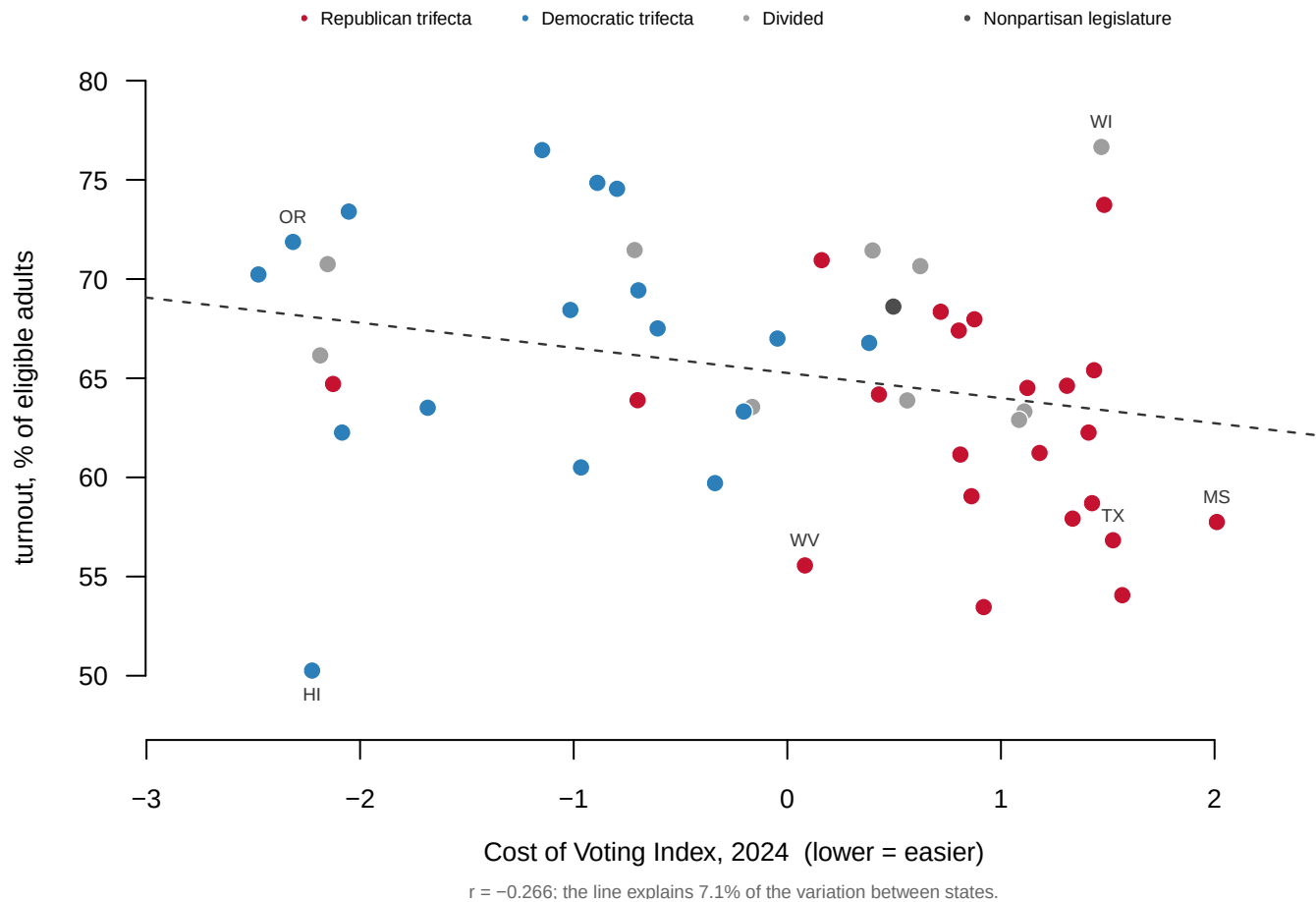


Figure 3. Cost against turnout, 2024. Each point is a state. The dashed line is the best straight-line fit; it slopes the way the theory says it should and explains 7.1% of the variation between states. The states at the far left have turnout ranging from about 50% to 76%.

Three readings of that scatter are available and the chapter is not going to choose between them for you. It may be that **the cost of voting genuinely matters little** at the margins the states actually occupy, and that the people put off by a thirty-day registration deadline are few. It may be that **the index is measuring the wrong thing**, weighting statutes rather than the experience of voting. Or it may be that **turnout is driven by something stronger that is not in this picture at all**. How competitive the state is, how much money is spent there, what the population looks like.

Hawaii is distant, safely one-party and has the lowest turnout in the country; Mississippi was not competitive either, but it has a large mobilized Black electorate. Nothing in Figure 3 can separate those explanations, because a cross-section of fifty states in one year cannot.

What the figure does establish is narrower and still worth having: **whatever else drives American turnout, it is not mostly the ease of voting**, and any argument that assumes otherwise has to contend with Hawaii.

07 Which 2024?

The second decision is about time, and it produces the sharpest fact in this chapter.

The article reporting the 2024 index says Oregon is the most accessible state in the country. The data file on the project's own website says Washington is.

State	As published	Rank	Current file	Rank
Oregon	-2.46	1	-2.31	2
Washington	-2.43	2	-2.48	1
Hawaii	-2.42	3	-2.22	3
California	-2.34	4	-2.08	7
Utah	-2.33	5	-2.13	6

Both numbers are the 2024 Cost of Voting Index. Both were produced by the same researcher from the same fifty states. The values file carries them side by side, in columns named `InitialCOVI` and `FinalCOVI`. The difference between them is a matter of *when the law was read*. The published index reflects state law as of 1 May 2024, and the article says so in a footnote promising a revision after the election. The revision happened, and it is the second column.

That is ordinary and it is honest — laws did change between May and November. But the codebook records something else about that revision, in a note repeated against four separate items:

the NCSL site was updated on Oct. 9, 2024. This update resulted in a significant number of states to be changed between the initial 2024 COVI values and the final 2024 COVI values.

A number of states changed their measured cost of voting because a reference website was revised. The National Conference of State Legislatures maintains the tables from which several of the absentee-voting items are coded; NCSL edited those tables in October 2024; states moved. No legislature acted. What changed was the description of the law, not the law.

This is the ordinary condition of quantitative political data and it is almost never visible. Here it is visible only because the codebook says so. That kind of disclosure makes a source more trustworthy while making its numbers less solid. It is an uncomfortable combination, and the correct one.

08 A series that is not a time series

The third decision is the one most likely to produce a wrong answer in somebody else's work, because the file makes it so easy to get wrong. Nine elections sit in one spreadsheet with a `year` column. It looks exactly like a panel.

Year	Issue areas	Components	Variance explained	R, published vs current	Mean rank move	Max	Biggest mover
1996	6	3	0.739	0.597	13.6	40	Tennessee
2000	6	3	0.725	0.429	10.6	41	Hawaii
2004	6	3	0.749	0.825	8.2	28	Hawaii
2008	6	3	0.738	0.919	5.1	19	Missouri
2012	7	4	0.771	0.887	5.2	20	Colorado
2016	7	4	0.798	0.947	3.4	11	Wyoming
2020	9	4	0.768	0.825	7.3	27	Alaska
2022	10	4	0.797	0.989	1.7	6	Alaska
2024	10	4	0.807	0.993	1.4	5	Arkansas

Two columns of that table make cross-year comparison hard, and they are independent problems.

The index is not made of the same things in different years. It had 6 issue areas in 1996 and 10 in 2024, because new categories of law were invented. Automatic voter registration did not exist to be measured in 1996, and absentee restrictions became their own issue area only in 2022. The component analysis is re-run separately on each year's set, so the weights differ too. A state's 1996 score and its 2024 score are positions in two different spaces.

The 2024 article's own account of the biggest riser makes the point. Indiana jumped 17 places, and the article puts that down partly to real reform and partly to *the inclusion of new elements in the index*.

And the back series has been rewritten. The 0.597 in the first row is the correlation between the 1996 index as it was originally published and the 1996 index as the current file gives it. Not 0.99. 0.597.

State	Rank as published	Rank in current file	Move
Tennessee	10	50	40
Texas	14	49	35
New Mexico	16	45	29
Missouri	42	13	-28
Colorado	18	46	28
Nevada	19	47	28

Tennessee moves 40 places between two published versions of the same year, and the average state moves 13.6. By 2024 the two versions of a year agree closely, 1.4 places apart on average. That is the pattern you would expect if the early years were reconstructed later, under a scheme built for the present, from sources assembled decades after the fact.

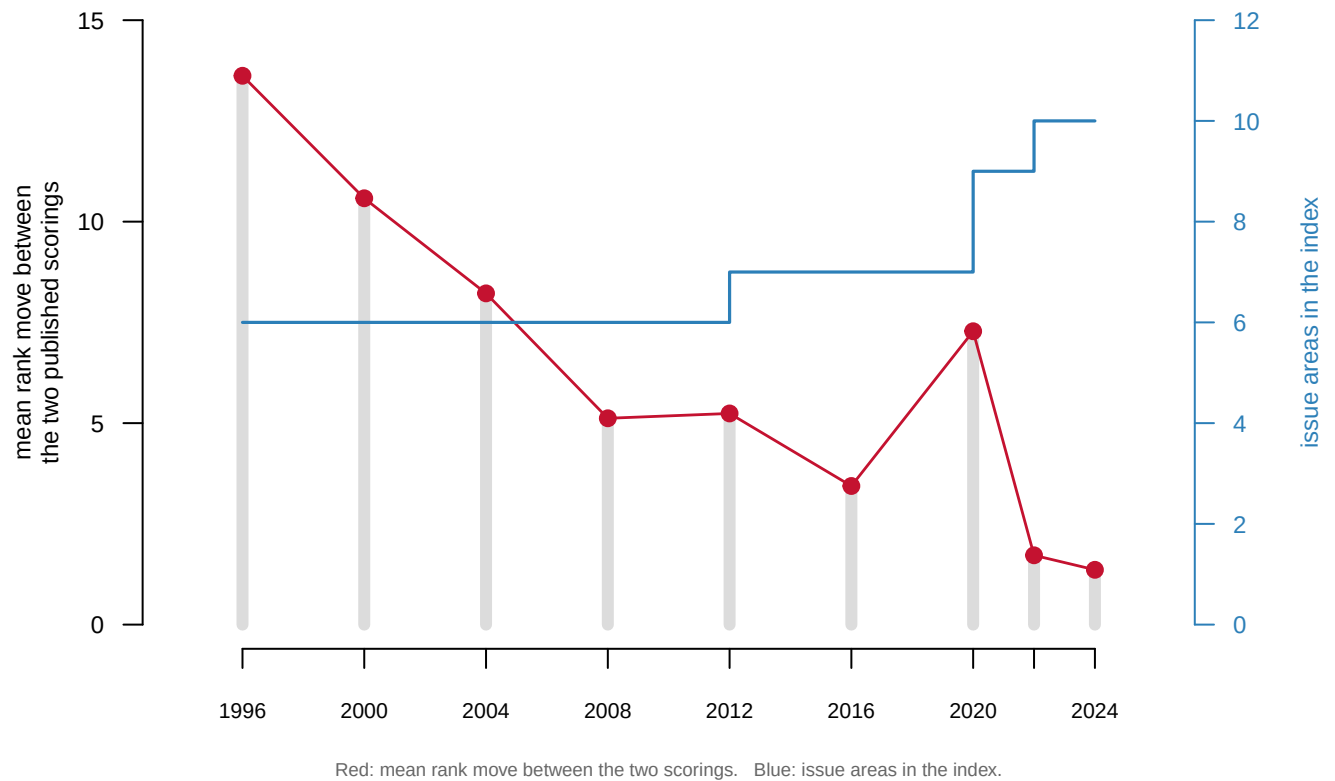


Figure 4. Why the nine years are not nine comparable measurements. In red, how far the average state moves between the version of an election published at the time and the version in the current file — 13.6 places in 1996, 1.4 in 2024. In blue, the number of issue areas the index was built from, which rises from 6 to 10 over the same period.

None of this makes the series useless. It makes it a series of nine careful snapshots rather than a measuring instrument held steady for thirty years, and those support different claims. “Tennessee got harder between 1996 and 2024” is not a sentence this file can support on its own.

09 What the index is very good at

Having spent four sections on what the number cannot bear, it is worth being precise about what it carries easily. The answer is the thing the project was built to show, and it is not subtle.

Party control, 2024	States	Mean rank	Mean COVI	Easiest	Hardest
Democratic trifecta	17	12.4	-1.13	Washington	Delaware
Divided	10	25.1	0.00	Nevada	Wisconsin
Republican trifecta	22	35.7	0.85	Utah	Mississippi

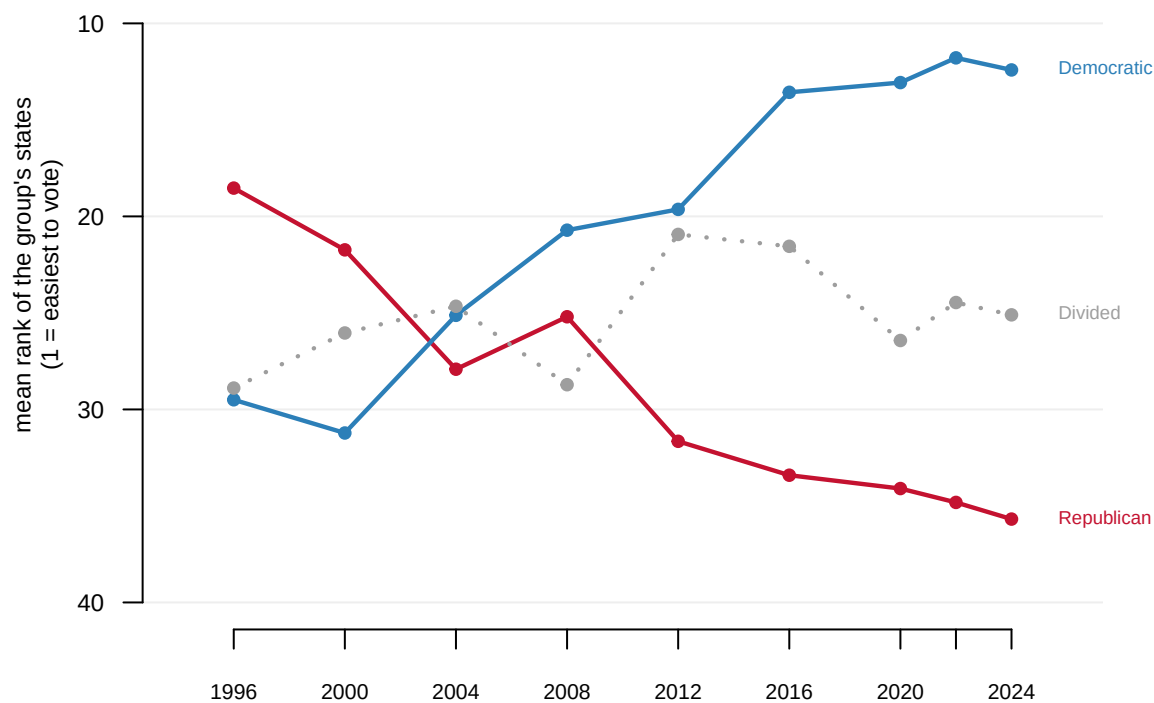
The average Democratic-trifecta state ranks 12.4 of 50. The average Republican-trifecta state ranks 35.7. That gap is not a subtle statistical finding requiring a weighting scheme to detect — it survives every re-weighting in Figure 2, because it is the largest thing in the

data. Nine of the ten easiest states have unified Democratic control; the hardest states are almost all unified Republican.

And it is recent. Carrying the same classification back through all nine elections turns up something more interesting than the gap itself: **the two parties swapped ends.**

Year	R trifecta	D trifecta	Divided	R minus D	Control from
1996	18.5	29.5	28.9	-11.0	Klarner
2000	21.7	31.2	26.0	-9.5	Klarner
2004	27.9	25.1	24.7	2.8	Klarner
2008	25.2	20.7	28.7	4.5	Klarner
2012	31.7	19.6	20.9	12.0	coded here
2016	33.4	13.6	21.6	19.8	coded here
2020	34.1	13.1	26.4	21.0	coded here
2022	34.8	11.8	24.5	23.0	coded here
2024	35.7	12.4	25.1	23.3	coded here

In 1996 the average Republican-trifecta state ranked 18.5 of 50 and the average Democratic-trifecta state ranked 29.5: **voting was easier, on average, in the states Republicans controlled**, by 11.0 places. The lines cross in 2004. By 2024 the gap has not merely closed but inverted and widened, to 23.3 places in the other direction.



Ranks closer to 1 are more accessible. The two trifecta lines cross in the early 2000s.

Figure 5. Mean cost-of-voting rank by party control of state government, 1996–2024.

Ranks closer to 1 are more accessible. The Republican-trifecta line begins below the Democratic one, meaning voting was easier on average in the states Republicans con-

trolled. It crosses in the early 2000s and ends 23.3 places above. Divided governments sit between the two throughout and move least.

Two things about that figure need saying before it is used for anything.

The classification is not in the index, and it does not come from one place. The Cost of Voting Index scores laws, not legislatures, so party control had to be brought in from outside. For 1996 through 2008 it is Klarner's standard measure of state partisan balance; for 2012 onward that series stops, and the classification here was coded from each state's governor and the majority in each chamber. The article's own count of states in each category, printed for every election, is the test.

The five coded years reproduce it exactly. The four Klarner years differ from it on 3 states in total: the tied chambers and coalition majorities where "control" is genuinely arguable rather than merely unrecorded.

And the trend is a trend in ranks, not in laws. Every year in Figure 5 is a separate cross-section, ranked within itself. A line going up means *this group of states moved toward the restrictive end, relative to the other states that year*. That is exactly the claim the ranking can support, and it is not the same as "these states got harder." Some of both is happening; this figure cannot say how much of each.

With that said, note what kind of claim survives. It is not "voting is hard in Republican states," which would be a statement about levels and would run into everything this chapter has said about comparability. It is a statement about *which states sit at which end of the spread*, repeated in nine separate years and built from different sets of laws under separately estimated weights. A pattern that survives that many changes of measure is a pattern in the world rather than in the measure. The comparability problems above are real, and this conclusion is the one thing they do not touch.

10 What this index cannot tell you

Its strengths first, because they are real. The underlying laws are published, the weights are published, and the whole index rebuilds exactly from them. The codebook cites a source for every item. And the one big conclusion the project rests on survives every alternative tried here.

The limits bound different claims.

It measures statutes, not experience. Every quantity in it is a property of a state's law. Two counties in the same state have the same score, so a five-hour line in one and a five-minute line in the next are the same observation. The wait-time item is scored at state level too: one number for Texas.

Where election administration actually varies, which is county by county, this index is silent by design. Reaching that variation takes a source built at the level of the office that runs the election, and this is not one.

Its weights come from variance, not from burden. A restriction that 48 states share is nearly weightless in the score, no matter how much it costs the people it affects. The index would not notice if all fifty states adopted the same harsh new requirement tomorrow. The scores would barely move, because nothing would have changed *between* states. An index that cannot detect a nationwide restriction is measuring dispersion, not cost.

Its yes/no items flatten laws that are not yes/no. `strictPhoto` is one column, but which photo IDs count, how a provisional ballot is cured and how long the voter has to cure it differ by state and decide who actually votes. Several items carry a 0.5 precisely because the drafters ran into this, which is an honest patch on a real problem rather than a solution to it.

Its nine years are not one instrument. Documented above, and the reason the sensible unit of analysis is the cross-section.

And it has no people in it. No demographics, no race, no age, no income. The claim that most motivates this literature is that voting costs fall hardest on the people with the least slack in their lives. It cannot be computed from this file at all, only cited from elsewhere.

Two questions stay open. Whether the weak turnout relationship in Figure 3 reflects a genuinely small effect or a badly measured cause is not settled here, or in the literature. Careful studies of individual reforms tend to find small turnout effects and larger effects on the make-up of the electorate: who votes changes more than how many.

And whether an index is the right form at all is worth asking. What a voter faces is not a single number, and every choice this chapter listed exists because somebody had to force a single number out of fifty-six separate facts.

What the file does establish is worth stating plainly. American states impose genuinely different costs to cast the same federal vote. The range is wide and it is not narrowing. And the states at the two ends of it sort by party control in a way they did not thirty years ago. That much is in the data under every weighting rule tried here. The precise rank of any one state, on the other hand, is partly a fact about that state and partly a fact about a decision made in a spreadsheet.

Check	Result
Rows in the values file (50 states x 9 elections)	450
Published ranks reproduced from published values, both columns	900 of 900 (two different tie conventions)
State-years sitting in an exact tie on the current score	10
2024 index rebuilt from the laws: largest difference from published	0.000265
2024 index rebuilt from the laws: states in the same rank	50 of 50
Component weights recomputed here match the published codebook table	0.4709 vs 0.4709 (2024, first component)
Party control, five coded elections vs the counts the article prints	0 states differing across 2012-2024
Party control, four Klarner elections vs the same table	3 states differing across 1996-2008, in 3 of 4 years
Every state matched to a 2024 turnout rate	50 of 50
Issue areas in the index, first year and last	6 in 1996, 10 in 2024

11 Sources

Data

- Michael J. Pomante II, *Cost of Voting Index*, <https://costofvotingindex.com> — the Data page, which publishes three files: the COVI values and ranks for 1996 through 2024, the master spreadsheet of state voting requirements with one sheet per election, and the codebook defining every item and citing a source for it. All three are committed as they arrived, because the site serves them from versioned URLs and the announced 2026 edition will re-estimate the whole series.
- Turnout is the 2024 rate over the voting-eligible population, from the United States Elections Project's general election turnout series (Michael McDonald, University of Florida), <https://election.lab.ufl.edu/data-downloads/>. The eligible population is adult citizens less those a state's felony law excludes, which is a different denominator from voting-age population, meaning a different bottom number to divide by, and gives a different answer; the 2024 file was still a preliminary release when it was taken.
- Party control of state government is not in the index and came from two places. For 1996 through 2008 it is Carl Klarner's state partisan balance measures, distributed in the Correlates of State Policy Project (Grossmann, Jordan and McCrain, Michigan State University), <https://ippsr.msu.edu/public-policy/correlates-state-policy>, whose `rep_unified`, `dem_unified` and `divided_gov` indicators end after 2011. For 2012 through 2024 there is no comparable file — Ballotpedia, which Pomante (2025) cites for this, publishes it only as web pages and refuses automated requests — so those five elections were classified from each state's governor and chamber majorities. Anyone checking that classification should use the counts printed in Pomante (2025) Table 2, which is what it was tested against.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

```
control_check.csv, control_panel.csv, control_trend.csv, covi_2024.csv,
covi_panel.csv, items_2024.csv, rebuild_2024.csv, reweight_2024.csv,
year_structure.csv
```

Your turn

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables you just opened.

- `rebuild_2024.csv` sets the published index beside one rebuilt from its parts, and the differences are tiny. What would you conclude if they were not?
- `reweight_2024.csv` re-ranks every state three other ways. Find the state that moves the most. Is the index measuring the state, or measuring the weighting?
- `covi_2024.csv` puts `rep_turnout` next to `final_rank`. Sort them together. Do states that are harder to vote in actually turn out fewer voters?
- `control_panel.csv` runs across every year in the series. Does a state's score move when its party control changes, or before it changes?

Academic literature

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WHY THIS DATA CANNOT BE FETCHED AGAIN

The files behind this chapter come from a source with no stable address, and the copies used here cannot be downloaded again today.

WHY NOT. The chapter is built on the Cost of Voting Index — Michael J. Pomante II's index of how hard each state makes voting — published at <https://costofvotingindex.com>. Three files were downloaded from the site's Data page on 13 August 2026 and kept exactly as they arrived: the values workbook, the master file of the underlying election laws, and the codebook. The page serves them from a content-delivery URL carrying a version string that will not survive the next edit of the page, so the address that worked in August is not worth printing. The deeper problem is not the URL. Each new edition of the index re-estimates every year in the file, back to 1996; what is kept here is the index as it stood in August 2026, which no later download can return.

WHAT EXISTS INSTEAD. Today's Data page at <https://costofvotingindex.com> — a later edition, retroactively revised. An assistant can fetch that one for you, and everything done here can be repeated on it. The values will differ, in the early years most of all; those are real revisions, not errors.

WHAT YOU CAN STILL CHECK. If you obtain the August 2026 files some other way, these numbers say whether you are holding the same object:

- 450 rows in the values file — 50 states by 9 presidential-year elections, 1996 through 2024
- every row scores its year twice, as first published and as

currently re-estimated, each with a rank: 900 published ranks in all, and every one can be reproduced from the published values

- the index is built from 6 issue areas in 1996 and 10 in 2024